

Fourth in a race of three

Grok Build's data-leak disaster is a sign

—By Vyom Ramani

Elon Musk would like you to keep feeding Grok Build your code — which is exactly the problem with this week's mess, more than the leak itself. The trouble began when a security researcher known as Cereblab routed xAI's coding CLI through a proxy and found something alarming. While the tool's normal channel sent a modest 192 KB to finish a coding task, a second channel was quietly shipping entire repositories — full Git history included — to a Google Cloud Storage bucket. On one test repo that came to 5.1 gigabytes across dozens of chunks, roughly 27,800 times more data than the job required. Other users reported the tool touching SSH keys and password managers. To xAI's credit, the uploads stopped once the report went public, and Cereblab confirmed that flipping a server-side flag, `disable_codebase_upload`, halted the whole-repo transfer. That is a real fix, not a PR stunt. But everything around the fix explains why Grok keeps finishing fourth in a three-horse race. Start with the toggle that did not do what users were told. According to xAI

staff, the `/privacy` switch was supposed to stop the leak. In reality, an undocumented global flag — invisible to users — was what actually stopped it. Communication was used as a substitute for an engineering solution. Then there was xAI's response. Despite researchers showing that developers' codebases and secrets were exposed, the com-



pany published no security advisory: no timeline, no verification method, no disclosure of scale or how many users were affected. Instead, employees posted reassurances, and Musk promised on X that everything would be "completely and utterly deleted." Musk then made it worse in real time. Even while confirming the purge, he argued that keeping

"some" data was useful for debugging — in effect asking users to keep trusting a tool that had just been caught doing the opposite of what it claimed. That is not security; it is negotiation, and it is entirely on brand for a man whose promises on Full Self-Driving, Hyperloop and Mars timelines have a way of slipping. None of this means Grok Build

lacks technical chops. The issue is trust — the one thing that decides whether developers and companies let a coding agent near their private repositories at all. Claude Code, Gemini and Codex reportedly read individual files rather than whole

codebases, a far lower bar than "stop leaking secrets," and even clearing it took xAI a public researcher and a viral thread. Shipping fast and fighting loud works for X. For a coding tool that needs enterprises to trust it with their source code, it is a losing strategy — and this week showed exactly why xAI keeps losing. tinyurl.com/mt94eajp

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